1963

In 1963, the M.S. Hershey Foundation formally offered $50 million to The Pennsylvania State University to establish a medical school and teaching hospital in Derry Township. With this gift and $21.3 million from the U.S. Public Health Service, the University joined with leaders from the Hershey community to build a medical school, teaching hospital, and research center in honor of Milton S. Hershey.



Our Legacy …

According to legend, it all started with one phone call …

Samuel Hinkle, then-president of the Hershey Chocolate Corporation (left) and Eric Walker, president of Penn State from 1956 to 1970, recreate the fabled "**$50 Million Phone Call**."

"Eric, this is Sam. You know Penn State really ought to have a teaching hospital."

"Oh, I agree Sam. But it's much too expensive to talk about."

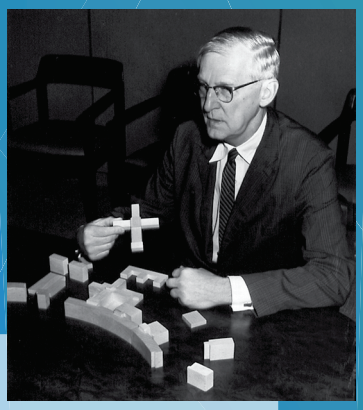
"How expensive, Eric?"

"Now Sam, you and I are just country boys. We can't even imagine how much … millions for sure."

"How many millions?"

"50 million."

"50 million? I think I could get you that."



1965

Founding Dean and Vice President for Medical Sciences Dr. George Harrell oversaw initial construction of the Medical Center and College of Medicine. Harrell used building blocks of the Medical Center to explain his vision for its growth. Among Harrell's innovations in medical education were the establishment of the first Departments of Humanities and Family and Community Medicine in any U.S. medical school.



1967

The first class of medical students was welcomed on September 25, 1967, while much of the Medical Center complex was still under construction. On June 5, 1971, the first class of thirty-four students graduated. Lois W. Forney was the first graduate of Penn State College of Medicine, earning a master's of science in physiology in 1969.

1970

On October 14, 1970, the Medical Center admitted its first patient to the hospital, Mrs. Nancy Nightwine of Hershey. Mrs. Nightwine was admitted by the Department of Family and Community Medicine for diagnostic tests.







1976

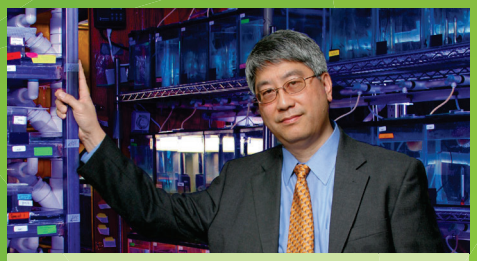
The world's first mechanical blood pump approved to support patients waiting for heart transplants was developed at the Medical Center in 1976 and is now used around the world. Penn State Hershey scientists and engineers are well known for having developed other heart assist devices and, in 1985, first used the Penn State Heart.

WHAT WILL YOUR LEGACY BE?



1977

In 1977, the Penn State Interfraternity Council/Panhellenic Dance Marathon, better known as THON™, began supporting the Four Diamonds Fund at Penn State Hershey Children's Hospital. The Fund was started by Charles and Irma Millard to honor their son Christopher, who lost his battle to cancer at the age of 14. The Four Diamonds Fund supports patients and families with pediatric cancer by off-setting the cost of treatment and paying for critical cancer support services at the Children's Hospital. The Fund also supports pediatric cancer research at the Children's Hospital.



2005

Dr. Keith Cheng published research that helped answer the age-old question, 'Why are people different colors?' By recognizing the similarities between the pigmented cells of light-colored zebrafish and humans and understanding their evolutionary kinship, Cheng's team identified a key gene change responsible for Europeans' light skin color. His work has wide-ranging implications, from understanding the causes of skin cancer to changing perspectives about the role of skin color.





1986

In 1986, the Medical Center began its Life Lion Critical Care Transport program, the first of its kind on the East Coast. Life Lion not only saves precious time, but also delivers care and treatment at the site of the emergency and while in the air. Life Lion includes state-of-the-art air and ground ambulance services and is a vital component of the Medical Center's accredited Level One Trauma Center.



2010

The College of Medicine has been a leader in the field of simulation education for nearly twenty years and opened the doors to a new, expanded facility in January 2010. The mission of the Penn State Hershey Clinical Simulation Center is to improve patient outcomes with effective programs that promote and enhance practitioner skills, clinical competence, teamwork, and interdisciplinary collaboration.



1994

Dr. Eliot Vesell, founding chair of the Department of Pharmacology, was a leader in the study of how genetics impacts drug metabolism. His landmark research showed that while identical twins metabolize drugs in the same way, fraternal twins do not. His work formed the basis of personalized medicine, which includes customizing medical therapies to the specific genetic make-up of individual patients.

2014



In September 2014, Penn State Health, a multi-hospital health system serving patients and communities across central Pennsylvania was created by the University. The system includes Penn State Health St. Joseph Medical Center in Reading, Pa., Penn State Health Milton S. Hershey Medical Center, Penn State Children's Hospital, Penn State Cancer Institute, and Penn State Health Rehabilitation Hospital (jointly owned), based in Hershey, Pa., as well as more than 1,300 physicians and direct care providers at 78 medical office locations.